What Convinces Them

See your work through the eyes of the person deciding.

Most storytellers start with their story. Strategists start with the person deciding. Before anyone says yes to your work, there are three things to answer. This workbook helps you answer all three before they ask.

01	Their Doubt	*What are they worried about?*
02	What you Deliver	*What proof can you show?*
03	The Difference	*Why this, and why now?*

START HERE

You don't need every part at once. Find their doubt, then answer the three D's for one real yes you need right now.

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Want help making your case? Book a free 15-minute fit call with Tasmiha and the Inkpactful team.

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PART 1

Find Their Doubt

Everyone deciding on your work asks the same three things, but the doubt, the proof and the reason to act look different for each person.

YOU ARE	THEY ARE	THEIR DOUBT: "CAN YOU DELIVER?" THEY NEED TO SEE	THE DIFFERENCE: "WHY THIS, WHY NOW?" THEY NEED TO SEE
Filmmaker	Funder or festival programmer	Finished past work, a cut or sizzle reel, a realistic budget and team	Why this story is urgent, who it reaches, how it fits their mission or lineup
Author or illustrator	Acquiring editor or agent	Sample pages or spreads, a finished manuscript, your readers	The reader waiting for this book, and the gap on the shelf it fills
Journalist	Editor	Clips, access to sources, a reporting plan	The news peg, and why their readers need it now
Creator or podcaster	Sponsor or audience	Consistent past work, engagement from the right people	Why your audience matters to them, and what they miss by waiting
Nonprofit	Donor or program officer	Outcomes from past programs, careful use of funds, a clear plan	What changes because of their gift, and what is lost without it
Business or freelancer	Client	Past results, case studies, a referral	The cost of the problem staying unsolved
Student	Scholarship or admissions committee	Finished work, grades, a recommendation	Where this opportunity takes you, and what you will give back

You don't need a new story for every person deciding. Keep the story and change what you lead with.

PART 2

Doubt, Deliver, Difference

Take 15 minutes and think about one real yes you need right now.

START Who has to say yes?

Name one person, not a crowd.

1 The person or group I need a yes from

2 What I am asking them to say yes to

3 What saying yes will cost them (money, time, page space, a grant they could give someone else, their attention)

D 1 Their Doubt

What are they quietly worried about? Say it in their words, before they have to.

4 Their doubt, in their words

D 2 What you Deliver

They want to know you can do what you say, not just that you care about it.

5 The proof I already have (past work, a result, a number, someone who will vouch for me)

6 The smallest sample I could show them right now

7 If my honest answer is “not yet,” what I need to build first

D 3 The Difference

Even if they believe you can deliver, they are deciding whether it is worth what it costs them, today.

8 Who got the yes last time? What pattern do they share, and what gap did none of them fill?

9 What happens if they say no, or wait a year

10 Why this matters to them, not just to me

11 What makes now the moment (a deadline, a change, a gap no one is filling)

12 One human detail that makes it real (a person, a quote, a moment)

PUT IT TOGETHER Two sentences

I can deliver because

This matters now because

AN HONEST CHECK

If one of their doubts is fair, strengthen the work before you polish the story. A good story cannot cover for a gap. It can only show what is already true. And if you have made your case honestly and the answer is still no, it may be the wrong room.

Not sure which doubts are fair, or which room is right? Talk it through with us on a free 15-minute fit call. INKPACTFUL.COM/BOOK →

PART 3

Lead With What You Deliver

The same story can win over a funder, an editor or a donor. What changes is the first thing they see.

13 Looking at your row in Part 1, which single piece of proof would this person care about most?

14 Rewrite your opening line so that proof comes first

15 Now picture a different person deciding (a funder instead of an editor, a donor instead of a client). What would you lead with for them?

SEE IT IN ACTION

One email, annotated

A real email I wrote after losing points on an exam. Names removed. Read it for the three D's, and for what is missing.

"...the most alarming component for me was how I was penalized for every single auscultation."	DOUBT It names one specific issue, not a general complaint.
"Before my OSCE, I was never instructed or taught not to use my stethoscope over my scarf... [my instructor] can attest to this as I've practiced multiple times in front of her."	DELIVER A person who can vouch for me. *Missing:* a sample, like an offer to redo the exam.
"I am happy to learn this new mistake and will be sure to implement this change as I move forward."	HONEST CHECK It accepts the correction while still making the case.
"I was wondering if it would please be possible to receive those points back."	THE ASK One clear request, easy to answer yes or no.
What I would add today	DIFFERENCE Nothing says why this matters to the reader beyond the points, or what it costs her to say yes.

Your turn: find these parts in the last pitch you sent. Which one is missing?

PART 4

Check Before You Send

Run these five questions before you send any pitch, grant, proposal or appeal.

- [ ] **Who exactly is deciding?**
  I wrote this for one person, not a crowd.

- [ ] **Can they see that I can deliver, early?**
  Proof shows up in the first paragraph, not the last.

- [ ] **Have I said why now?**
  I named what is lost if they wait or say no.

- [ ] **Is there one human detail they will remember?**
  A person, a quote, a moment.

- [ ] **Is the yes easy to give?**
  One clear next step, with nothing for them to figure out.

> LAST PASS
>
> Read it once as a skeptic. Any claim you cannot back up, prove it or cut it.

PART 5

Build Your Proof Bank

This is your Deliver. Most of us have more proof than we think. It is just scattered across inboxes, phones and memory. Keep one running list, so you never start from scratch when someone asks.

Results
Numbers, outcomes, awards, a sold-out screening

Samples
A page, a clip, a pilot, a published piece

People who vouch
Quotes, referrals, partner letters, an editor's note

Human moments
A person, a quote, a scene that made the work real

DATE	WHAT HAPPENED	TYPE OF PROOF	WHERE I CAN USE IT

Add one entry a week. A year from now, your proof will be ready the moment someone asks.

ABOUT TASMIHA

Tasmiha Khan is an award-winning storyteller covering health equity, immigration and caregiving, with bylines in *The New York Times*, *TIME* and *National Geographic*, and a quote in *Fast Company*. A Knight Science Journalism Fellow at MIT, she has secured more than $200,000 in competitive grants and fellowships, and she is the only hijabi woman to receive the 2025 Peter Lisagor Award. President Obama invited her to the White House for her social impact work. She began in medicine, left it for storytelling, and now helps creators and changemakers make the case for their work.

Want help making your case? Book a free 15-minute fit call with Tasmiha and the Inkpactful team. You'll leave knowing which doubt to fix first, and whether we're the right fit.

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